was club captain and he talked to me, got me involved, right from the start. It's not just hindsight: you could tell then that David was going to make a manager. He knew straight away what I was about, that I'd be quiet, keep to myself and just talk when I needed to. He put himself out to bring me into the group, to look after me, and I really appreciated that.

Gary Peters, the manager, was brilliant as well. It probably helped that he was a Londoner too. He made it clear what he needed me to do and gave me the confidence to do it. He seemed to really believe in me. He must have watched me playing for the reserves at United and I found out later that he'd asked about taking me on loan almost as a joke, not thinking the club would agree. He couldn't believe it when the boss said yes. I understand Preston even put a bid in for me after the loan spell, but Gary knew that really would have been pushing their luck.

It all happened very quickly. I trained with them on the Monday then Gary put me into the reserves on the Wednesday, which felt quite strange. Preston played in the Central League, like United's reserves, and beforehand it almost seemed like I'd fallen on hard times. But once you're out there playing you forget all that. I did all right, set up a goal and scored one myself. So, come the Saturday, I was on the bench for the first team against Doncaster at home.

It was a bit of a surprise when Ryan Kirby, who I'd played alongside for so many years with Ridgeway, lined up for Doncaster. My dad was up for the game, of course. And so was Ryan's dad, Steve, who'd also done some of the coaching when we were kids. For me and Ryan, it was a quick hello and then we had to get on with it.

One thing I wasn't really looking forward to was the tackling. I'm sure that's part of the reason the boss sent me to Preston in the first place, to harden me up a bit. I was a lot more fragile then than I am now. That first game, I sat on the bench for the first half and, every time a tackle flew in, I was cringing. I wasn't exactly looking forward to getting on. When I did, though, almost straight away we got a corner. It was a really blowy afternoon, with the wind behind us, and I remember thinking I'd just whip the ball in to see what happened. A goal. Not a bad way to start. We ended up coming from behind to draw 2–2.

The next game was against Fulham, who had Terry Hurlock playing for them. Now, I knew Terry by reputation and I'd watched him play: here was a bloke who liked a tackle and I was worried about getting whacked by him. As